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SSLP 2022

Becca Park SSLP Final Project

Bethany Catholic Worker House

ND Club of Rochester

Cover Page

Brief description of the mission of the organization:

Bethany House is a Catholic Worker House of Hospitality located in Rochester, NY that has offered women and children, who are in need of hospitality, shelter and support since 1977. In addition to providing shelter, Bethany House strives to support the local Rochester community through their food pantry services, which provides food, clothing, baby formula, diapers, and hygiene products. Overall, Bethany House aims to give those who are struggling within the Rochester community a leg up in life; to help show them what true, undeniable love, passion, and hope is. Their motto, which I believe speaks so true to what Bethany House is all about, is, “we will love you, until you can love yourself.”¹

My primary responsibilities included:

1. Supervising and running food pantry operations (preparing food and supply bags, logging community member’s information into the food pantry log, taking food pantry appointments)
2. Personally responsible for all women and children guests staying in the house (supervising their actions within common room areas, checking their chore completion, checking off their sign out sheets, communicating with guests to support them as best as possible)
3. Cleaning and restocking house supplies

¹ [Bethany House-Catholic Worker House of Hospitality](#), The Catholic Worker Movement

Advice for future students at this organization:

Bethany House is truly such a memorable place. Staff, guests, and community members are treated alike and given so much love that truly, this place is family. Many of the women and children staying in the house have had hard and complicated lives whether that may be in connection to domestic abuse, drug addiction, prison, mental health setbacks, and/or homelessness, so be prepared to have an open mindset. I felt that because of the many hardships the guests at the house have experienced that it can be hard to hear and try to comfort them as all you want to do is take away their pain, but all you can do is listen to them, maybe give them advice, but most importantly, be there for them. Things you encounter may be tough to witness or surround yourself in, but it is worth it. I promise you. Be prepared to be challenged, but also, be prepared to witness and feel a one of a kind love that words can not even begin to describe.

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1. Identifying your Audience:

Throughout my time at Bethany House, I have seen many individuals struggle with the lack of attention or services of their case workers. This issue is not just centered around Rochester, and is rather a prevalent concern throughout our nation. Therefore, this presentation addresses Monroe County Officials, especially to the Monroe County Office of Management and Budget and Monroe County Caseworkers. While also, indirectly, I hope my paper speaks to the Rochester community as a whole. Monroe County Caseworkers are tasked with, “doing work that matters” work that will ultimately

improve lives, improve communities, and improve futures.² Monroe County has set up branches as evidenced by their one division called the, “Budget and Management Committee.” This branch manages the budget of departments such as Human Resources, which includes the resources for case managers. The branch helps manage departments to foster efficiency and productivity. Thus, in the case of the department “the Monroe County Caseworkers,” Monroe County’s Budget and Management Committee helps them access all the resources they need in order to help fulfill their mission of assisting people of the Rochester community that are in stressful situations due to financial, emotional, or social issues. Ultimately, they are responsible for monitoring and improving the well-being of families and children. The issues I will discuss will not change solely from one county, department, or singular person. Rather, it will take a change in multiple, if not all of Rochester, to truly make an impact for the betterment of Rochesterians as a whole.

2. **Narrative:**

Before delving into my time at Bethany House, I feel that it is important to describe what home is like in Rochester, NY. For us Rochesterians, we all come from different backgrounds, different cultures, or different ends of the color spectrum. But, we all make up this palette that paints this beautiful city we call home. Drive through Rochester and on one corner you can see the highlights of Puerto Rican culture. To another edge, the riches of African American Heritage. From above, a city colored with various wavelengths of light, creating our own unique color set of identity. Yes, we are Rochesterians.

Having been born and raised in Rochester, NY, I can’t help but feel a sense of pride being born in such a historic city where Eastman Kodak, Bausch and Lomb, Xerox,

² Caseworkers.org, Monroe County Caseworkers

the Underground Railroad, the Women's Rights movement, etc. have all taken place here. Yet, I feel as though in more recent times, Rochester has changed. From making national headlines of police conflict with African American Daniel Prude's death by asphyxiation to, most recently, Officer Anthony Mazurkiewicz' death while on duty. I hoped my time at Bethany House would show me the good again in Rochester's community, and while it definitely has shown me the pure intent of compassion and love, I feel that a newfound sense of frustration was instilled within me.

This was most evident when I walked into Bethany House on a Sunday morning. It's one of my last days at the house. I walk into the staff office, reading through case and log notes as sunshine flooded throughout the house, sun-kissing my face. To be honest, reading through notes was just a means to pass time. I was really waiting to see two of our guests as it was their last day at the house before their allotted 45 day stay.

My heart skipped a beat as I heard the familiar, comforting sound of pitter-pattering down the upstairs hallway. Bursting into the office door was - for the sake of confidentiality of these guests I have changed their names - Kayla and Nina. The best way I can describe this perfect mother daughter duo would be a literal walking ray of sunshine, and as Nina describes her daughter, Kayla, they've always been, "attached to the hip ever since she was born." To say the least, Nina and Kayla have always been such a delight to be around. They just bring this sense of warmth and this feeling of fresh air to the house.

Kayla ran into the office in her usual bright pink t-shirt and tie-dye leggings, embracing me in the biggest bear hug one could give all the while laughing and giggling as we said good morning to each other. I went over to Nina, but today she had this look of

worry, which was very unusual compared to her normal bubbly self. I asked her what was wrong with which she replied explaining how she was extremely stressed regarding their housing situation as they still have not found shelter. I asked her if her case worker had done anything to provide her with additional housing resources, or if her case worker had reached out to any places regarding if they could help them. Nina looked back at me and I could just sense this sort of frustration she feels towards her case worker. She explained how over the past few weeks she had tried to get in contact with her case worker, leaving multiple voicemail messages and pleas for help. She further explains in frustration, how she feels unsupported and almost hated by her case worker, giving an example of how her case worker had called her noncompliant in front of her judge. In exact words, Nina explained, “I feel like I’m choking. Like I...I can’t breathe.”

In that moment, all I could really do was comfort Nina, give her words of encouragement, and maybe give her some more housing resources to call, but ultimately, I too felt frustrated. Powerless. Helpless. Lost. As Nina was making phone call after phone call, trying to find a place for her and her daughter, I made brunch for the both of them. As I was cooking my mediocre grilled cheese, bacon, scrambled, and sunny side up eggs, my stomach just turned into a knot. I couldn’t help but think about all the children within our nation who are just like Kayla, a 14-year old girl who has done nothing wrong in her life, and yet, having to witness, at such a young age, obstacles that no child should ever have to witness, let alone experience.

3. **Analysis:**

I feel that a common problem among all the guests I interacted with was the lack of availability, care, and reachability of their case managers. I saw many common frustrations the women felt at my site regarding their case managers from a guest’s

inability to reach their case manager to schedule a dentist appointment, resulting in them waiting in a prolonged period of pain, or the inability of Bethany House staff to reach a guest's case manager regarding a guest's health condition.

I feel that there is a huge misunderstanding between both case managers and clients, and because of this, there is an unnecessary growing animosity between them both. I believe because of this rift, those who are in need of help and those who are choosing to help, cannot grow together. As Dorothy Day saw, poverty is supposed to be an awakening call to action for us all to work together - it was not meant to be used as a means to further division.³ The knowledge and sight of poverty within our society should not be used as a means to further divide, it must be used as a means of motivation for us to passionately bring up and grow with those within our community who are struggling.

While the issues I have described are primarily related only to what I have witnessed at Bethany House, the issue between case managers and clients are nationwide, and have consequently further rifted apart our community from our ever continuing journey of betterment. I felt that there were two prominent issues from both case managers and clients at Bethany House that further rifted them, which I also strongly feel are applicable on the national scale:

1. Many times guests at Bethany House would have many appointments made by their case managers during the week. However, due to many factors such as mental health, health conditions, conflicting schedules, and/or forgetfulness guests would miss their appointments. Or, if they tried to last-minute get in touch with their case managers regarding when their appointments were, they would be

³ ["Poverty Results from Structural Barriers, not Personal Choices. Safety Net Programs Should Reflect That."](#), Heather Hahn, Margaret Simms

unable to get in touch with them before their actual appointment slots. Due to missing appointments, it may have led case managers to feel as though their clients were noncompliant or unserious about the resources they have made available for them. Thus, further rifting the relationship between case manager and client.

2. Many of the guests and staff at Bethany House felt that the case managers we worked with were unavailable and emotionally uninvested. Many times both guests and staff tried to get in contact with case managers for information, help, conflicts, etc., but were put to voicemail. Some situations included when guests required immediate help or immediate contact with their case managers, but when we were unable to get in touch with them it caused serious stress and feelings of frustration from both guests and staff. Thus, further rifting the relationship between case manager and client.

I firmly do not believe that the tensions and issues we have seen between case managers and clients have started out of nowhere. Rather, I believe due to a lack of resources as well as a shortsided perceptions of one another has greatly influenced the issues we see today.

First, I want to showcase the lack of human resources that case managers utilize in comparison to those who are in need. For instance, individuals living in marginalized communities continue to face inadequate care due to the shortage and stress of existing social workers in the system. Human resources are so scarce that around 85% of counties within the United States have inadequate or no behavioral health services⁴. Factors such as need growing faster than capacity, geographic disparities, lack of investment in community services, drug abuse, and an aging population all continue to strain and crumble our nation's social care system,

⁴ [“The Behavioral Health Care Workforce Shortage — Sources and Solutions.”](#), Kate Jackson,

which has consequently negatively impacted millions living within our communities⁵. These main points further exemplify why more social care resources are needed in order to combat the further growing disparities among our communities. 85% of counties within the U.S. having inadequate health services is a national concern. This number should signify to Monroe County Officials that not only more material resources must be invested but also more care, attention, and love must be given in order to start seeing real, genuine changes. Human resources includes divisions such as child and family services, staff development, employee benefits, family assistance, medicaid, adolescent care, office of mental health, etc.⁶ Therefore, this lack in inadequate resources signifies that there are not enough funds to support case managers let alone give them enough space and funds to properly help support their clients.

Furthermore, studies have shown that many case managers employ a type of schematic thinking that preemptively categorizes their clients into the "type" of consumer who would disengage from services, which thus impacts the quality of care from social worker services to their clients⁷. It was also found that some case managers even placed the responsibility for disengagement on the consumer, placing the consumer responsible rather than on the social care system, which has failed to reach many people who were in need of help⁸. On a daily basis, case managers face consumers disengaging, however, they must strive for a more holistic approach - an approach not solely based on potential future outcomes - that provides more flexible and open-minded services that will ensure that consumers stay in services and benefit from them.

Studies have also revealed that it is extremely common for case managers to experience burnout; this work-related burnout can be caused by a number of factors such as: unrealistic

⁵ ["The Behavioral Health Care Workforce Shortage — Sources and Solutions."](#), Kate Jackson,

⁶ [Monroe County Budget](#), Monroe County Budget 2022

⁷ ["Understanding Service Disengagement from the Perspective of Case Managers."](#), Victoria Stanhope

⁸ ["Understanding Service Disengagement from the Perspective of Case Managers."](#), Victoria Stanhope

expectations, excessive documentation, lack of appreciation, low salary, and/or job related stress.⁹ Not only is there a problem of a lack of resources for case managers, but also confounding this problem is the issue of inequivalent compensation and mental health care for our social workers. One source explains, “There is the stress of not knowing what you’re walking into... this affects you physically, mentally, behaviorally — all the ways it plays out in life.”¹⁰ On top of that, just looking at Monroe County case workers salaries, their starting salary is a mere \$42,378¹¹. To put this number into perspective the yearly salary for a minimum wage worker in New York is \$31,200. In order to become a certified case manager, the American Case Management Association requires that one must complete at least a Bachelor’s Degree in Healthcare Management or a related field including social work, nursing, or human services.¹² For case managers to spend 4 years of college tuition to work for our nation in a high-stress job environment with minimum mental health or salary benefits is a huge hole within our system.

4. **Proposal:**

Below, I am proposing 3 different solutions that I hope Monroe County can implement - then, for our nation to implement in suite. I believe these solutions can help bring, what Clemens Sedmack describes, “a spirituality of justice,” which is an expression of real, genuine love.¹³ I hope this aspect of Catholic Social Tradition helps guide our community towards true, authentic development of the whole person by linking social and economic change to personal growth.

1. Increase funds towards human services - more specifically, towards hiring more care management personnel

⁹ [Casemanagementbasics](#), Martin Gardner

¹⁰ [Stress Can Create Physical and Mental Health Problems for Case Managers](#), Relias Media

¹¹ [Caseworkers.org](#), Monroe County Caseworkers

¹² [How to Become a Certified Health Care Case Manager](#), The Chicago School of Professional Psychology

¹³  [CST primer Clemens.pdf](#), Clemens Sedmak

- a. In 2019, the Monroe County Annual Report states that through their Department of Human Services, around 1,000 employees delivered services to the residents of Monroe County.¹⁴ This number does not include only case managers; the figure of 1,000 could include the various personnel working in different divisions of human services. However, let's say for argument's sake that all 1,000 were case managers employed by Monroe County. The total population of Rochester, NY is around 210,000 people with around 30.4% of the population in poverty.¹⁵ This means that there are 63,840 Rochesterians who are in poverty. Since the average caseload per case manager is from 25-49 cases¹⁶, this means that if there are 1,000 case managers, the maximum number of cases Monroe County Case Managers could manage is 49,000. I propose that we increase the number of case managers we have to a figure of around 1,300. I want to preface that I do not believe that the solution in funding this increase in case managers is to increase taxes on our citizens. Rather, I propose an in-depth analysis on the efficiency of our current budget must be taken into account, and from these figures, budget allocations must be made from certain programs to fund this increase in case managers.
2. Create case manager training programs and evaluations more tailored towards a well-rounded care program for their clients
 - a. I believe due to case managers preemptively categorizing their clients into the "type" of consumers who would disengage from services, this caused many of the guests at Bethany House to have feelings of frustration towards their case managers. Because of this, a change must be made. I am proposing a higher

¹⁴ [Annual Report 2019](#), Monroe County

¹⁵ [Rochester Demographics](#), United States Census Bureau

¹⁶ [Average Caseload](#), Chordline Health

emphasis that implore case managers to view, and thus, treat all of their clientele with the care, services, and compassion that each individual deserves. To help motivate this, I am proposing that mandatory training programs that emphasize a well-rounded care program as well as an added section within case manager's evaluations that specifically will include the level of care and compassion each client feels they received, will help motivate social workers to provide their best effort with each of their clients.

3. Improve salary standards and mental health support benefits for case managers
 - a. Case managers require a bachelor's degree as well as passing a civil service exam prior to becoming certified. A salary of around \$42,000 is extremely low in addition to the minimal mental health benefits. I propose that their salaries and health care benefits must be improved in order for case manager's well-being to improve, which will thus also improve the quality of care clients receive. The average salary of a worker who has obtained a bachelor's degree is around \$69,000/year¹⁷. Therefore, I propose that at least case manager salaries be raised to \$60,000/year with added health benefits with a focus on mental health support programs. Again, the money to support these additions would come from re-budgeting to better allocate funds towards case managers.

Overall, I firmly do not believe that neither case managers nor clients are purposely trying to disregard one another's feelings or time, rather I believe it is the lack of resources, training, and care within the social system that is creating this widening gap between those who are reaching out for help and those who are choosing to dedicate themselves to help. The common good commits us to be interconnected with those who are in need of our help, which

¹⁷ [Average Salary by Education Level](#), Northeastern University

Catholic Social Traditions describes as the principle of solidarity¹⁸. I believe that once these changes have been made within the Monroe County social service system that we can see a significant improvement and growth for our community as a whole - from which, I hope will continue to spread throughout the nation. I hope that Catholic Social Tradition will inspire, motivate, and call us to action, inviting us to challenge and to think of how we can imbricate our world together to form new, bettering traditions. As Pope John XXII explains, “It is not enough merely to formulate a social doctrine. It must be translated into reality.”¹⁹ Overall, Catholic Social Tradition seeks to concern us with the matters of justice that allow for the whole and every person to be authentically embraced and accepted within a world founded on principles of love and compassion.

5. Anticipating Questions/Concerns:

I anticipate that one of the main concerns would be the means to fund an increase in budget towards human resources. Monroe County receives a good majority of our budget from our dedicated taxpayers, however, it is important to realize that in 2021, only 42.9% of United States residents paid income tax while 57.1% paid no individual income tax.²⁰ I believe that increasing taxes on the 42.9% of residents would further economically stress these individuals. I propose that rather than increasing taxes we should do an in depth analysis on our current budget allocations in order to prioritize the areas that we need to focus on - for example, a greater focus on human resource divisions that are struggling with adjusting to changing demographics.

Furthermore, I anticipate that a concern would be with clients abusing case manager evaluation surveys. For example, what if clients rate their case managers poorly based solely on

¹⁸ [The Welcome Table](#), Notre Dame Center for Social Concerns

¹⁹ [The Welcome Table](#), Notre Dame Center for Social Concerns

²⁰ [Percentage of Households in the United States that paid no individual income tax in 2021, by income level](#), Statista

personal feelings regarding their performance outcome, rather than looking at case manager performance holistically. In the case of teacher evaluations, teacher evaluation systems heavily rely on classroom observations conducted by principals or other school administrators with the help of rubrics/checklists.²¹ Similarly, there needs to be a 3rd party involved with case manager evaluations to further help the ethicality of this evaluation system.

6. Personal Commitment:

Both my Mom and Dad immigrated from South Korea to Rochester, NY. My Dad when he was 14 years old and my Mom when she was 35 years old. I grew up hearing stories from my Dad, moving to the city of Rochester with no money or resources. But despite having nothing, his dreams of finding newfound success and happiness for his family were born in Rochester. The city of Rochester gave my Dad hope. Shelters such as the Salvation Army of Rochester gave him a leg up in life with resources such as clothing and food. Simply, it is the love, care, and compassion of Rochesterians that gave my family a fighting chance to break free from the bonds of poverty and socioeconomic hardships. It is this fighting chance and my parent's dreams for a better future that gave me this beautiful life: a life filled with good health, comfort, love, and opportunities. This beautiful life I have, I can't explain how lucky and fortunate I am. I love Rochester, and is why it saddens me to have seen some of the vibrance fade away throughout our city; from Kodak's bankruptcy, the division of race within our city, the poor state of our city school system, drug addiction, homelessness, daily homicides, cracks within our health services, etc.

Rochester gave me everything, and I feel strongly that my story can be applied to any other city within our nation. It is because of this, in addition to my experience at Bethany House, that I want to continue to work towards finding these cracks within our social systems to better

²¹ [Teacher Evaluations](#), Stephen Sawchuk

our community, nation, and world. Human beings are social creatures; we are not meant to live in this world alone. I want to continue to work together, imbricating our nation to progress together without the expense of losing one another along the way.